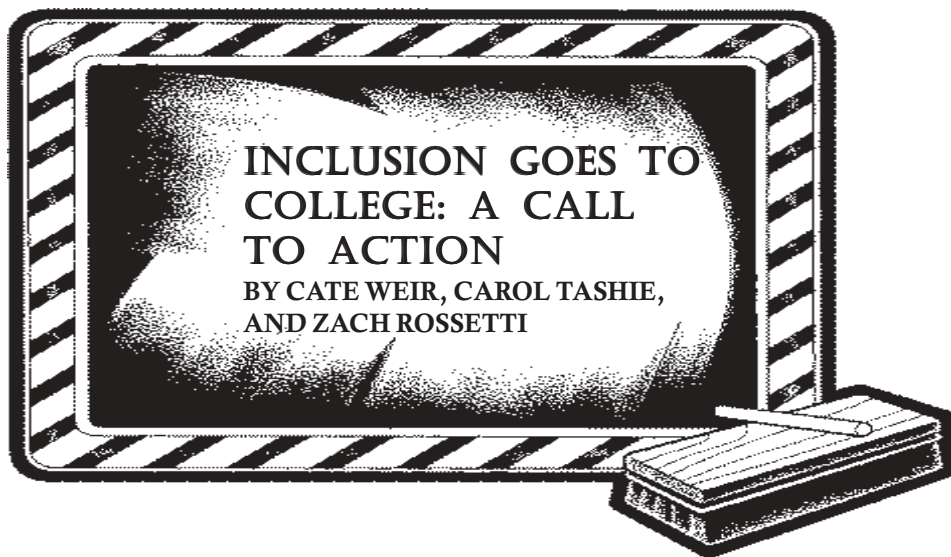




For all of her life, Kathy was told her disabilities would prevent her from achieving academic goals, especially the pursuit of a college education. Her high school years were spent sitting in special education classrooms, excluded from the college preparatory classes she wanted to attend. “College is out of the question,” she was told. Her teachers and guidance counselors encouraged her to be “realistic” about her future plans. But Kathy wouldn’t listen.

When she was 27 years old, she contacted the local college and said, “I want to take some classes.” And now, two years later, she is pursuing her college degree at the New Hampshire Community Technical College at Manchester. The college has provided accommodations, tutorial support, and assistive technology that assist her in achieving her goals. Vocational rehabilitation provides support in goal setting and in purchasing equipment she needs. The local adult support agency provides help at her home with class assignments. The Assistive Technology Low Interest Loan program lent her money to buy a computer. And most importantly, Kathy has provided

the energy, hard work and unwavering commitment to her goal. Together, this collaboration works to support Kathy’s dreams.

Jesse is also a college student, studying Veterinary Technology. In many ways, she is a typical college student. She studies hard, worries about exams and struggles with the Latin terms in animal anatomy and physiology. But if you ask her about her experiences, you will realize she is also, in many ways, unique.

Jesse has many labels that have led many people to believe she doesn’t belong - and never would succeed - in college. But she is succeeding in her goal to attend college and earn an associate’s degree. Jesse is reaching her goal with the help of hard work, family support, an individually designed major that fits her career goals, and an academic advisor that knows her potential and is working creatively with Jesse and the college faculty. In her own words: “When I was born, they told my parents I should be in an institution. Well, today, I am in an institution, but it’s an institution of higher education.”

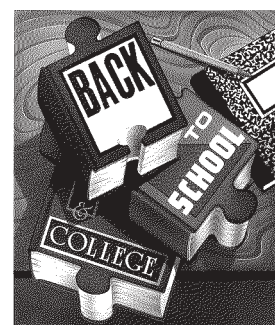
In the past few years, individuals with labels of severe disabilities and their families have been declaring that access to college must be a choice for everyone. Advocates like Kathy and Jesse and others have challenged society’s prejudices and taken their rightful places on college and university campuses throughout the country. But just as it was when

students with severe disabilities moved from fully inclusive elementary schools to high schools that were less than welcoming, there remains the perception that higher education is “unrealistic,” “too difficult,” or even a “waste of time and money” for some people.

Although it is widely acknowledged that higher education is critical in terms of employability and lifelong earnings, it is still commonplace to exclude people with labels of severe disabilities from college, based on out-dated notions of disability and achievement. But is it reasonable and just to advocate for full inclusion in elementary and high schools, and still allow college to remain outside the grasp of so many? In other words, does full inclusion go to college?

The struggle for educational equity for students with disabilities has been expanding since the beginning — from the front door to the classroom door,

from elementary school to high school, from social integration to high academic expectations. For twenty-five years, powerful advocacy has taken place to assure that all students have real places in their public schools. But, in that same period of time, rarely has college been discussed. For many, there continues to exist a belief that individuals with severe disabilities could never be successful in college. This misguided reality, based on out-dated assumptions about what labels mean in terms of intelligence and competence, is often coupled with paternalism and motivated by a desire to protect people from what is imagined to be certain failure. These factors work together to make dreams of college seem silly, unrealistic, and even dangerous for certain people.

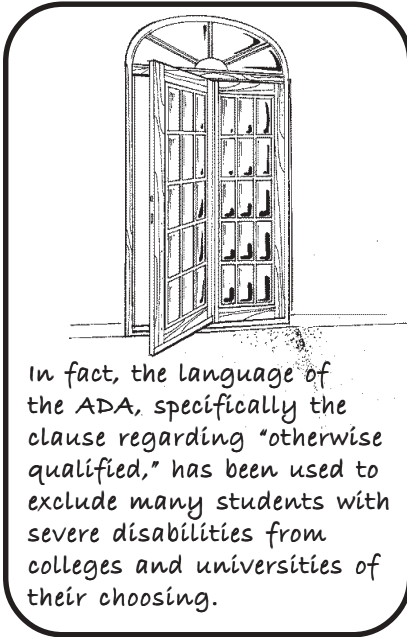


“When I was born, they told my parents I should be in an institution. Well, today, I am in an institution, but it’s an institution of higher education.”

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INCLUSION GOES TO COLLEGE: A CALL TO ACTION

Continued from page 14



In fact, the language of the ADA, specifically the clause regarding "otherwise qualified," has been used to exclude many students with severe disabilities from colleges and universities of their choosing.

Along with these assumptions and fears about disability and college success, there also exists a passive approval of the entrance criteria colleges use to judge suitability for acceptance. These criteria continue to be based on narrow definitions of intelligence, potential, and academic success. Therefore, when a high school algebra teacher claims that a student with severe disabilities doesn't belong in her classroom, the challenges are loud and sustained. But when a college admission counselor advises the exact same thing, there is curious silence. It is time to dispute exclusionary practices at colleges and universities.

The passage of the Rehabilitation Act of 1973 made it illegal for the vast majority of colleges and universities to discriminate on the basis of disability. However, it was not until the passage of the Americans with Disabilities Act in 1991 that most post secondary institutions began to take this responsibility seriously. As a

result, the percentage of students with disabilities attending college has increased, from just 2.6% in 1978 to 11% in 1997. However, this increase reflects primarily those students with disabilities who still fit the mold of a "traditional" college student. In fact, the language of the ADA, specifically the clause regarding "otherwise qualified," has been used to exclude many students with severe disabilities from colleges and universities of their choosing.

One of the challenges to this call to action is that colleges and universities, by nature and design, have historically been exclusive places. Higher education has been used throughout time to "separate the wheat from the chaff," and to educate only a "worthy" subset of our citizens. But why do we need to continue to accept this? President Clinton, in his 1997 State of the Union address, pronounced "... every 18-year-old must be able to go to college, and all adults must be able to keep on learning." Those of us who advocate full inclusion for all citizens must begin to challenge this exclusive domain.

In order to ignite this change, we must also challenge the attitudes of paternalism and protectiveness that limit people's choices and chances, at the cost of real self-determination. Assumptions about ability and capability have led many of us to advise students to avoid college, because we "know" how hard college is and we "believe" they don't have what it takes to succeed. Although this may be seen, by some, as a "kindness," oppression in the name of protection is still oppression.

As a result of the activism of individuals and their families, as well as the work of a few federal initiatives, the doors to a college education are beginning to crack open. There are students with labels of severe disabilities who are pursuing their educational dreams and, in so doing, shattering many of society's assumptions. However, in our haste to move forward, some dangerous missteps are occurring. Some colleges are designing or hosting

programs that do little more than move the special education classroom to the college campus. Some school districts are developing partnerships with one or more community colleges to run "transition programs" for their post-graduates with severe disabilities. Some colleges are allowing students with severe disabilities access to nonacademic classes, with little regard for student choice, grades, or college credits. And while some may view these things as "a good start" or "better than nothing," it is indeed a slippery slope down which dreams of inclusive college communities can easily slide. We must learn from the past and refuse to support the development of special classes or programs on college campuses, for they, like special education classes in public schools, will eventually need to be dismantled in favor of real inclusive choices.

It is time to recognize that the values and beliefs of inclusion — labels are not informative, disability is a social construct, and all of us are enriched by a diverse community — apply to higher education as well. We must work to support people with severe disabilities in the attainment of their goals and acknowledge that, in fact, inclusive education means college, too!

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